

he composed his earliest opera, *Artaserse* (1741). Its success prompted further works in the then fashionable genre of opera seria. After visiting London (where he met Handel) in 1745, Gluck settled in Vienna in 1752. That year, he composed his most boldly inventive opera seria to date, *La clemenza di Tito* (The Clemency of Titus) to a Metastasio libretto that was later set by Mozart.

Increasing success

During the 1750s and early 1760s, Gluck also wrote on mythological themes for the imperial court, and composed several French *opéras comiques*. These culminated in *La Rencontre imprévue*, whose plot and Turkish harem setting influenced Mozart's *Die Entführung aus dem Serail*. But the two key events of these years were the revolutionary ballet *Don Juan* (1761) and the opera *Orfeo ed Euridice* (1762), his first collaboration with the librettist Ranieri de' Calzabigi (see [box](#)), and a milestone in operatic history.

Then came two more operas whose classical plots and integration of solos, chorus, and ballet unified Gluck's and Calzabigi's dramatic principles. The aim of *Alceste* (1767)—according to its foreword—was to achieve “simplicity, truth, and naturalness” in form, plot, and language. In *Paride ed Elena* (1770), Gluck avowedly depicted “the different characters of two nations, Phrygia and Sparta, by contrasting the rude, savage nature of the one [Sparta] with all that is delicate and soft in the other.”

The last years of Gluck's career centered on Paris. Beginning